AN EXERCISE ON LISTENING

PASTORAL COUNSELING

Pastor Juancho visits Saturnino on his 87th birthday. Manong Saturnino lives in a house together with the family of his daughter. Her husband opens the door and leads Pastor Juancho to Manong Saturnino in his room, reading a newspaper. The son in law leaves saying: There is someone for you!

Pastor: Hello, Manong Saturnino. My name is Pastor Juancho. I am the new pastor of UCCP Mahayag Church. I come to greet you a happy 87th birthday!

Saturnino: Thank you pastor. Please have a seat! (points toward the armchair across the room. Between them there is a small table)

Pastor: Thank you (unwraps a present from the congregation and takes out the letter, on which the age of 87th is marked. He hands over both things to Manong Saturnino). Oh I see, you are already 87 years old!

Saturnino: Yes, one has to take it as it comes. And nothing is working anymore as it used to: My heart, my breath…neither my sight clear anymore.

Pastor: I see a lot of newspapers and books here. So at least you can still read a bit!

Saturnino: Yes, but it's hard. I need a magnifying glass. Without it, it doesn't work anymore. And on the street I don't recognize the people anymore. Except by their way to walk maybe.

Pastor: So then your daughter probably takes care of you?

Saturnino: Yes, I don't cook anymore myself. But I prepare my breakfast and read the newspaper. Then I go to the graveyard and sit a bit before I come back home. That's how I pass my days. In the last days however, it doesn't work anymore.

Pastor: Yes, it's really hot these days, isn't it?

Saturnino: I can't breathe anymore. My lungs….That's the age, I guess…

Pastor: You know, even younger persons are suffering from this weather. I am sweating like crazy, as soon as I go out.

Saturnino: Oh, then you shouldn't be outside much!

Pastor: I think we all should take care not to exhaust ourselves. A while ago you mentioned you recognize people by the way they walk. Are those friends with whom you keep contact and go out with?

Saturnino: I don’t really know anybody anymore. My friends have passed away. And I am the last one left of my siblings—we were 7 altogether. Last year 2 brothers passed away. One was 92!

Pastor: a very high age!

Saturnino: Yes and my wife passed away 18 years ago. Much too early. She was only 63.

Pastor: That’s really very early!

Saturnino: Well, we have no choice. It’s fate. We have to take it as it comes. All of us have to die. One is due earlier, the other one later. We all live towards death.

Pastor: Right. So we should really make the best of the time that’s left.

Saturnino: I agree. Well, a year ago I could still go downtown. But now I cant do it anymore….

At this point the conversation was interrupted, which I would have liked to continue. The son in law asked us to come to the living room. His wife joined us. Another conversation started, in which Manong Saturnino kept very silent.